

LittleReads

The Little Lion Who Learned to Listen

Life Skills

Ages 5–7

by LittleReads Editorial Team

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But the golden savanna of West Africa, there lived a little lion called Leo.
Leo had the biggest mane of any cub his age and the loudest roar.

Chapter 1: Leo Never Listens

"Leo, do not run near the river!" his mother would call.

But Leo would run anyway. SPLASH! He would fall in, and his mother would have to fish him out.

"Leo, do not eat those red berries!" his teacher would say.

But Leo would eat them anyway. Then his tummy would hurt, and he would miss play time.

"Leo, wait for me!" his friend Zuri would shout.

But Leo would race ahead, leaving Zuri behind.

Everyone told Leo the same thing: "You must learn to listen!"

But Leo never listened to that either.

Chapter 2: Trouble at the Waterhole

One morning, Leo's mother told him an important story.

"Today, the river is running very fast because of the rain last night. You must stay away from the waterhole, Leo. It is dangerous."

Leo nodded, but he was already thinking about playing near the river with his friends.

Sure enough, Leo went to the waterhole anyway. The water was rushing and swirling, just as his mother had said.

"It does not look so bad," Leo muttered to himself.

He stepped closer. Then closer. Then he reached out a paw to touch the water —

WHOOSH!

The rushing water grabbed his paw and pulled. Leo slipped and fell into the muddy riverbank, stuck in the thick, sticky mud.

Chapter 3: Stuck

Leo tried to pull himself out. He pushed with his legs. He scratched with his claws. But the mud held tight.

"Help!" he cried. "Someone help me!"

But his friends had gone home. His mother was far away. The river rushed past, and the mud pulled at him.

Leo felt scared. For the first time, he wished he had listened.

Just then, he heard a slow, deep voice.

"Well, well, well. A little lion in a big pickle."

It was Uncle Hippo, who lived downstream.

"Uncle Hippo! I am stuck!" cried Leo.

"I can see that," said Uncle Hippo. "Did your mother tell you to stay away from the river today?"

Leo lowered his head. "Yes."

"And did you listen?"

"No," whispered Leo.

Chapter 4: A Helping Hand (and Hoof)

Uncle Hippo waded into the shallow part of the river and carefully nudged Leo toward the bank. With a mighty push, he freed Leo from the mud.

Leo lay on the dry ground, breathing hard.

"Thank you, Uncle Hippo," he said.

"You are welcome," said Uncle Hippo. "But next time, listen to your mother. Listening is not just about hearing words. It is about caring. When your mother tells you something, she is caring for you."

Leo thought about this. "When I do not listen, it is like I am saying I do not care about what she says?"

Uncle Hippo nodded. "Exactly. And when Zuri asks you to wait, and you race ahead, how do you think she feels?"

Leo remembered the times Zuri had looked sad when he left her behind.

"She probably feels like I do not care about her," said Leo quietly.

Chapter 5: Learning to Listen

Leo went home and told his mother everything. He told her he was sorry for not listening. He told her he understood now that listening means caring.

His mother nuzzled him gently. "I am glad you are safe, Leo. And I am proud of you for understanding."

The next day, Leo ran to find Zuri.

"Zuri! Wait for me! I want to walk with you!"

Zuri smiled. "Really? You want to walk with me?"

"Yes. I am going to listen more. I want to be a good friend."

And from that day on, Leo listened — to his mother, to his teacher, to Uncle Hippo, and most of all, to his friends.

He still had the biggest mane and the loudest roar. But now he also had the biggest heart.

What We Learned

- Listening is not just hearing words — it is caring about what others say.
- When we do not listen, people we love can get hurt.
- It is brave to say sorry and change.
- Good friends listen to each other.

Discussion Questions

1. Have you ever gotten into trouble because you did not listen?
2. How does it feel when someone does not listen to you?
3. What can you do to remember to listen more?

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Thank you for reading!

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